

A woman with blonde hair is lying on a floral patterned couch in a rustic cottage. In the background, there is a stone fireplace with a fire burning. The text "ON THE Cottage Couch" is overlaid in a pink, brush-stroke font.

ON THE
*Cottage
Couch*

*my girlfriend
did it in front
of me.*

EVAN SLATE

ON THE COTTAGE COUCH

My girlfriend did it in front of me

Evan Slate

PMI

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"That's not how you hold a poker hand, James, oh my god!" Jade plucked the cards from his fingers and rearranged them, her knee purposefully, if secretly, pressing against his thigh as she leaned over the arm of his chair. "See? Together, then build your hand."

"I'm not going for a hand." James let her fuss with his cards anyway, watching her face instead of his hand, a knowing grin spreading over it.

"Well you should have been." She dropped herself back into her own seat on the couch and crossed her legs, her bare foot coming to rest against his thigh and she laughed as though to herself. "Liam, are you even playing anymore or are you just going to sit there nursing that beer all night?"

I set down my cards and picked up three new ones from the deck. "I'm playing."

"He's sulking." She grinned at James. "He gets quiet when he's losing."

"I'm not sulking."

She stretched her arms over her head and the hem of her shirt rose up to show a strip of skin above her jeans. "James, tell him he's sulking."

James discarded two cards and drew replacements. "I'm staying out of it."

Jade threw a poker chip at him and it bounced off his shoulder. She was already reaching for another one when he caught her wrist.

"You're a terrible shot."

She twisted her hand but didn't pull away, just looked at him with that communicating smile playing at the corners of her mouth.

He released her and she immediately launched another chip that hit him square in the forehead.

She turned to me.

I laid down three tens and took a drink.

"That's all you've got?" She dropped her cards face down without showing them. "I'm bored with poker. Let's play something else."

"Truth or dare." James gathered the cards into a pile and set them aside.

"God, what are we, seventeen?" Jade was already sliding off the couch to sit cross-legged on the floor in front of the fireplace. "Liam?"

"Sure."

She looked back at James. "I go first." She twisted to look up at him. "Truth or dare."

"Dare."

"I dare you to tell me the real reason you invited us up here this weekend." Her hand came to rest on his knee, casual as anything.

"That's a truth question."

"Answer it."

"Maybe I miss my old squeeze." He glanced at me, checking.

"We were never any good for each other." Now she glanced at me, pulled strands of hair over her eyes as though to hide herself. But I saw the grin she couldn't suppress.

I finished my beer and set the bottle down. "My turn."

Jade looked at me. "You have to be asked first."

"Truth or dare, Liam." James's finger traced a circle on the back of Jade's hand. She causally rolled her hand over to let him draw it on her palm, watching me all the while.

"Truth."

"Boring," Jade said.

"Does it bother you?" James brought his eyes to me. "Me and Jade?"

Jade went still.

"No." I finally said. I reached for another beer from the six-pack by my chair. "Should it?"

"He's lying." Jade turned her whole body toward James now, her back to me. "He's absolutely lying. Look at his jaw."

"I'm not looking at his jaw." James brushed a strand of hair away from her face. "I'm looking at you."

"My turn." Jade's voice dropped lower, more intimate now. "James. Truth or dare."

"Truth this time."

She shifted closer to him, both her hands sliding up his thighs and she looked hard at him with drama. "Did you really not think Liam was going to come this weekend too, or did you expect me to bring him?"

James tilted his head, considering. "I knew he was coming."

"That's not an answer."

"I might have mentioned there was plenty of room. That you should bring your boyfriend." His fingers found the end of her braid and he tugged it gently. "I might have been curious to see what's changed in you."

"And?" She turned her face up toward his. "Have I?"

"Not even a one little bit." He snorted.

She laughed and twisted to look back at me over her shoulder. "See? James thinks I'm exactly the same as I was at twenty-two. Is that true? Am I exactly the same?"

I twisted the cap off my beer. "You tell me."

"So cryptic." She rolled her eyes and turned back to James. "He's being cryptic now. This is his other move, besides sulking."

"Maybe he's tired," James said, but he was watching me as he said it, and there was something challenging in his expression, too.

Jade got up on her knees, bringing herself level with James. "Are you tired, baby?"

"I'm fine."

"He's fine." She looked at James, took his face in her hands. "See? He's fine. Not bothered at all." Her hand came dropped down to rest on James's chest, fingers spread over his top. "Your turn to ask him something."

"Truth or dare, Liam."

"Dare." I kept my voice even.

James seemed to think about it, his hand coming up absently to cover Jade's hand on his chest, play with peeling her fingers away one by one. She watched the play closely. "I dare you to go get more firewood from the shed. We're going to need it if we're staying up much longer."

Jade twisted around to look at me. "It's freezing out there."

"There's a coat by the door," James said.

I stood up. "Fine."

"Wait." Jade scrambled to her feet and crossed to me, rising up on her toes to kiss my cheek. Her lips lingered there for a moment, hot against my skin. "Don't be long," she whispered, but loud enough that James could hear. "You can't trust that man." She looked at James and laughed.

I went to the door and pulled on the barn coat hung there, oversized and smelling of wood smoke. The cold hit me as soon as I stepped outside, sharp and clean after the close warmth of the cottage. The shed was maybe fifty yards away and I could feel them watching me through the window as I receded.

Inside the shed I stood for a moment in the dark, listening to the wind in the trees. I could have grabbed the wood and gone right back. Instead I let myself count to sixty, then to ninety, giving them time to do whatever it was they were going to do the moment I was out of sight.

When I came back with an armload of split logs, I found they had moved. Jade was now in the chair tucked against Jame's side with his arm draped around her shoulders. Her legs were pulled up and she had her head resting in the hollow of his shoulder. They were talking quietly, and didn't immediately look up when I shouldered through the door.

"You were gone like forever." Jade lifted her head but didn't move away from James. "We thought maybe you got lost."

"It's fifty yards." I dropped the wood by the fireplace and took off the coat.

She poked James in the ribs. "Move over, let me out, you pig."

"You seemed comfortable where you are."

She extracted herself and padded over to me, wrapped her arms around my waist from behind as I stacked the logs.

She pressed her face against my back. "You're all tense."

"I'm stacking wood."

"You don't have to, make James do it." She turned me around to face her, hands on my chest now, looking up at me with wide eyes. "We're just talking."

"Looked like more than talking."

"Jealous?" The word came out playful, teasing.

"Should I be?"

She stretched up and kissed me, slow and deep, her tongue sliding against mine deep in my mouth. When she pulled back she was smiling. "Maybe you should be a little." Then she took my hand and led me back to the fireplace, pushing me down into my chair before returning to her spot with James.

He pulled her back against him without hesitation, his hand coming her to rest on her hip. "Truth or dare, Jade" he said intimately.

"Dare," she responded just as softly.

"I dare you to tell Liam about the summer after graduation."

Her body stiffened. "That's a truth question."

"Answer it. You made me answer yours."

She fell quiet for a moment, her fingers tracing patterns on his knee.
"What about it?"

"All of it."

"Liam knows about that." But she didn't look at me when she said it.

"Does he know all of it?" James's thumb moved in circles on her hip, familiar and possessive. He hooked his thumb in her belt loop, pulled on it.

"There's not that much to know." She shifted, pressing herself closer against him. "We hung out. We had fun. It was just a summer thing."

"It was more than a summer thing."

"It was whatever it was." She turned her face up toward his. "It's ancient history now anyway. I'm with Liam now."

She reached up and touched his face, her fingers tracing along his jaw in a gesture so intimate it felt like I shouldn't be watching. "Truth or dare, James."

"Dare."

"I dare you to kiss me like you did before in front of my boyfriend." She paused a moment then burst out laughing and looked over her shoulder at me as though to check how her little joke went down.

I stood up. "I'm getting another beer."

But James had already bent his head toward hers, and Jade's eyes had already fluttered closed in anticipation. I walked to the kitchen and stood at the counter in the dark, listening to the silence from the other room that meant they were doing exactly what I thought they were doing.

I gave them a full two minutes before I walked back in. They had separated by then, but barely. Jade's lips were darker, swollen, and she was breathing harder. James had his head tilted back against the chair, eyes half-closed, his hand still resting on the curve of her waist. When I sat down, neither of them acknowledged me right away.

"That was..." Jade stopped, laughed a little, touched her mouth. "That was exactly like that night." She bit her lip looking up at his mouth from close.

"It 'was.'" James's voice had gone rough around the edges.

She shifted in his lap and I saw his fingers tighten on her hip, caught the slight hitch in his breathing. She had to feel what she was doing to him. Had to know. It felt like things were moving past merely teasing, having a bit of fun.

I came up with her because it felt like she was going to take up this James's invitation either way, and I had a sense I'd better be there. I knew they had a history, and Jade was one of those fun girls always flirting around.

I took a long drink and watched them. Jade's chest was rising and falling faster than normal, her pupils dilated in the dim firelight. When she moved against him again it was on purpose, a slow roll of her hips that made his jaw clench. She was testing something, or maybe proving something, and the charge in the air had changed entirely. She enjoyed making me jealous, teased me about it going home from parties, but always made it up to me in bed after.

This time, it felt different. This was an old boyfriend.

"Liam." She said my name without looking at me. "You're being so quiet."

"Just watching."

"Watching what?" Now she did turn, though she stayed pressed against James. Her cheeks were flushed, her eyes bright.

"You two."

Her hand slid down James's chest, came to rest just above his belt. I watched his stomach muscles contract under her touch. I had a feeling she was enjoying teasing James as much as me with it, doing this to him in front of her new boyfriend.

She bit her lower lip, that gesture she used when she wanted something from me and knew how to get it. "Does it bother you?"

She turned back to James, brought her mouth close to his ear. "I think he likes watching." She said it quietly but made sure I could hear, and then she snickered and glanced back at me.

James's hand moved from her hip to her lower back, fingers spreading wide. "Does he?"

"Mm." She kissed his neck just below his ear, and I watched his eyes close. "He's got that look. All intense and focused. It's his turned-on look."

"Jade." I kept my voice level.

"What?" She glanced back at me, all innocence, except for her hand sliding lower on James's stomach. "Am I wrong?"

I was not going to give her that. "It's your turn to ask someone."

She twisted to settle more fully into James's lap now, her back against his chest, legs draped over the arm of the chair. His arm came around her

waist, holding her there. "Truth or dare, Liam." Her eyes came right on mine.

"Truth."

"Are you getting hard watching us?"

The question landed like a stone in still water. James's hand flexed against her stomach. She stared hard at me and didn't break.

"Jesus, Jade." My voice betrayed me, coming out rougher than I intended.

"That's not an answer." She was watching me with that predatory focus she got sometimes, like she had caught the scent of something she wanted.

"Come on. Truth. That's what you picked."

She surprised me. She wasn't bursting out laughing.

"I'm not answering that."

"So it's a maybe." Now she laughed, low and satisfied, and moved against James again. This time there was no mistaking it for anything but intentional. I saw his breath catch, saw his other hand come up to grip the arm of the chair. "He's maybe getting hard. How about you? Are you maybe getting hard?" She grinned up at him as she squirmed in his lap.

"Jade." His voice was strained like mine.

"That's not an answer either." She took his hand from her stomach and brought it higher, pressing it against her ribs just below her breast.

"Everyone's being so evasive tonight. I'm the only one being honest." She popped a finger of his between her lips, sucked on it, pulled it out and snickered.

"Are you being honest?" I said.

"Always." Now she held my gaze while she pulled James's hand higher, until his palm covered her breast through her top. She made a small sound in her throat. "See? Honest. I like being touched."

James's thumb moved across her nipple and she arched into his hand, head falling back against his shoulder. "That's, like that." She breathed out.

"Jade." I said her name like a warning, though I was not entirely sure what I was warning her about.

She opened her eyes and looked at me, her hand covering James's hand now, holding it harder against her. "You look so tense, baby. Maybe you should go to bed. You must be exhausted."

"I'm not that tired."

"Are you sure? You've been yawning." I wasn't. "Haven't you noticed him yawning, James?"

"Can't say I've been paying attention to Liam." His other hand had found the strip of skin between her shirt and jeans, fingers tracing her there.

"We can finish the game without you." Jade's voice had gone breathy. "If you're too tired. James and I like to stay up. We're night people. Remember, James? How we used to stay up until sunrise?"

"Yeah, I remember." He casually squeezed her whole breast in his hand.

"We'd talk for hours," she came back to me. "About everything. About nothing." Her hips moved again and this time James made a sound low in his throat. "We were good at keeping each other up."

"Well I'm not going anywhere." I finished my beer and immediately regretted not having another one ready.

She twisted in James's lap so she was straddling him, facing him, her back to me now.

James's hands found her hips, settling like they belonged there. Jade braced her palms on his chest and leaned in close, her hair falling forward to fall like a curtain around both their faces. I couldn't see what expression she was making anymore, could only see the line of her back, the way her body curved toward his.

"Mm. You have really good eyes. I forgot how good." Her fingers moved to the collar of his shirt, tracing along the edge. "And you're warm. You were always so warm."

One of his hands slid up her spine, under her shirt, skin on skin. I watched the fabric bulge over his moving hand as he explored the architecture of her back. She made a soft sound and pressed closer, eliminating the space between them.

"Do you think this is okay?" she asked him, not me.

"Yeah." His other hand joined the first under her shirt, both palms flat against her back now. "It's okay."

She rolled her hips forward in his lap, a slow grind, and his head fell back against the cushion. "What about that? Is that okay too?"

"Fuck, Jade."

"I'll take that as a yes." She puffed air out her nose and did it again, and I could see the tension in his shoulders, the way his fingers dug into her skin. "I forgot how good you feel."

I cleared my throat. Neither of them reacted. Jade's hands moved to his hair, fingers driving through it as she brought her mouth to his neck. She kissed him along his jaw, his throat, the spot below his ear. I watched his eyes close, watched his hands slide lower down her back, thumbs hooking into the waistband of her jeans.

"Remember the boathouse?" Her lips moved against his skin as she spoke. "That afternoon when everyone else went to town?"

"I remember."

"What did we do in the boathouse, James?" She bit gently at his earlobe and he groaned.

"You know what we did."

"Tell me anyway." She was moving steadily against him now, a rhythm that made his breathing ragged. "I want to hear you say it."

His hands slid around to her stomach, fingers splaying wide just above her waist. "We fucked in the boathouse."

The word hung in the air between all of us. Jade made a pleased sound and kissed him hard, her tongue sinking deep into his mouth. I watched his hands move higher, thumbs brushing the underside of her breasts through her bra. She moaned into his mouth and ground down harder against him.

When she pulled back they were both breathing hard. "We fucked so many times that day." Her hands went to his shirt buttons, unfastening the top one. "In the boathouse. In your car. In your bed when your parents were at dinner." Another button. "On the dock at three in the morning."

"Jade." I said her name but it came out uncertain, like I was not sure I had the right to interrupt.

She didn't turn around. "What, baby?"

"Maybe slow down."

Another button came out. Her fingers spread the fabric open, revealing his chest. She bent and kissed his collarbone, his sternum. "We're just talking. Just reminiscing." Her tongue traced a line down to his navel and James's hips jerked up involuntarily.

"I don't think that's just talking."

"No?" She sat up and finally looked back at me over her shoulder. Her lips were parted, her eyes dark and unfocused. "We're talking about the past." She turned back to James and undid another button. "What else did we do that summer? Help me remember."

James's hands cupped her breasts now, no pretense of restraint or hiding it. "You're playing with fire," he groaned.

"I like the fire." She arched into his touch. "You remember how I liked the fire? How I liked..." She stopped, bit her lip, pushed down harder against the obvious bulge in his jeans. "How I liked everything?"

"I remember." One of his hands slid into her hair, gripping it at the base of her skull. "You were insatiable."

"I was." She smiled against his mouth, not quite kissing him. "Am I different now? Liam, am I different now?" She looked over at me with her face against James's.

I didn't answer. I was not sure she actually wanted me to.

"He's not talking anymore." She kissed James again, sloppy and hungry. "I think we broke him. Or maybe he's tired after all. Are you tired, baby? You can go to bed if you want. We'll be quiet."

"You're never quiet," James said.

She laughed breathlessly. "That's true. I'm not quiet at all. Especially when I'm..." James's hand slid down to cup her ass, pulling her harder against him, and whatever she was going to say dissolved into a gasp. "Especially when I'm really enjoying myself."

I stood up. Neither of them noticed. James had both hands on her ass now, guiding her movements against him. Jade's head fell back in pleasure, exposing the long line of her throat. Her shirt rode up and I could see his fingers digging into her skin, could see the way her whole body was responding to him.

"I'm getting more wood." My voice sounded strange in my own ears.

"Okay." Jade's response was distracted, automatic. She didn't look at me. "Don't freeze out there." She sank into an even deeper kiss with him, her fingers tugging at his hair now.

I walked to the door and pulled on the coat again. Before I stepped outside I looked back. Jade had her hand between them now, palm pressed flat against the front of James's jeans. He was kissing her neck, her shoulder, anywhere he could reach, and she was saying something to him too quiet for me to hear. Whatever it was made him groan and pull her hips harder against his.

I stepped out into the cold and closed the door behind me.

I stood in the shed longer this time, long enough for my hands to go numb, long enough to question whether I should go back at all, or just head

upstairs and let whatever was happening happen without me as a witness. But some sick curiosity kept me rooted there, counting the logs stacked against the wall, listening to my own breathing in the darkness. Was it a mistake to come up? She was going to come up anyway. This was going to happen.

When I finally went back to the cottage I moved quietly. The door didn't creak. My footsteps on the hardwood were soft.

They were still in the chair by the fireplace, but everything had changed. Someone had pulled the heavy knit blanket from the back of the couch and it was draped over Jade's lap now, covering both of them from the waist down. Her shirt was still on but rumpled, twisted, riding high on her ribs. James's shirt hung completely open.

I set the wood down carefully by the hearth. Neither of them looked up. Neither of them acknowledged my presence at all.

Jade's head was tucked into the crook of James's neck, her face hidden. Her shoulders were moving in a rhythm that made my chest tighten. Under the blanket I could see motion, could see the subtle shift and rock of her hips. James's hands were underneath it too, lost somewhere in that covered space where I couldn't see what they were doing.

"Fuck, you're so..."

"I know." She cut him off with her mouth on his, swallowing whatever he was going to say. The blanket shifted with the intensity of her movements and I caught a glimpse of his hand, saw where it had to be, what it had to be doing.

I sat down in my chair. The fabric creaked under me but they didn't react. I might as well have been invisible, might as well have been in another room.

Jade broke the kiss to gasp for air, her fingers digging into his shoulders.

His hand moved faster under the blanket and she whimpered. She was grinding down against something, chasing friction, chasing release.

His free hand tangled in her hair, pulling her head back so he could kiss down her throat.

"James..." My name came out sharp.

But he didn't stop. His mouth found the hollow of her throat, her collarbone.

She was shaking now, trembling against him. He did something that made her cry out. Her whole body went rigid, then shuddered, a full-body

tremor that rolled through her in waves. She buried her face in his neck and made broken sounds against his skin, her hips still moving in smaller and smaller circles as she rode it out.

James held her through it, whispering things I couldn't hear, his hand still moving gently under the blanket. When she finally went limp against him he wrapped both arms around her, the blanket still preserving whatever privacy was left.

I sat there in my chair, beer forgotten, watching them breathe together. Jade's hand disappeared under the blanket too now, and I saw James's expression change, saw his breath catch.

"Jade, he's right..." But whatever protest he was forming died when her hand moved. His hips jerked up involuntarily and he groaned.

Her hand was working steadily now, I could tell from the rhythm of his breathing, from the way his knuckles went white gripping the arms of the chair. She kissed him slow and deep while her hand kept moving. She stopped, did something that made him curse. His hips were moving now too, thrusting up into her grip.

"We should stop," she whispered. I almost didn't hear it.

"I know." But his hand was still moving under the blanket, gentle circles that made her eyelids droop.

"This is..." She didn't finish the thought. Instead she kissed him, slow and deep, while her hand resumed whatever it had been doing. He groaned into her mouth and his other hand came up to cup the back of her head, fingers driving through her hair.

They kissed like that for a while, unhurried but intense, hands working under the blanket in a rhythm that built so gradually I almost didn't notice it building. Jade would make a sound and James would respond by doing something that made her grip his shoulder harder. He would tense and she would slow down, draw it out, make him wait, smirk against his lips.

I watched the blanket shift and settle with their movements. Watched Jade's breathing get shallower, watched James's hand slide under her shirt to spread across her lower back. They were crossing lines but doing it so slowly, so incrementally, in the dark and quiet, that each incremental touch seemed inevitable.

Jade pulled back from the kiss, panting. "James."

His forehead pressed against hers again. But even as she said it her hips moved forward, seeking more contact.

She was quiet for a moment, breathing hard, clearly debating. Then she shook her head slowly at him and made a funny pouting face.

His hand resumed its movement and she made a sound low in her throat, equal parts relief and surrender. Her own hand matched his rhythm under the blanket and I watched his head fall back against the chair, watched the cords in his neck stand out.

They found a tempo together, something slow and torturous that made them both tremble. Every so often one of them would whisper something and the other would nod or shake their head or respond with words I couldn't hear. I was completely shut out of whatever conversation was happening between them.

Jade shifted her weight and the blanket slipped, threatening to reveal what was beneath. James caught it and pulled it back up, preserving the barrier between what I could see and what I could only imagine. Whatever they were doing belonged to them alone.

Jade turned her head just enough to look at me over her shoulder, though her body stayed pressed hard against James. Her cheeks were flushed, her eyes glassy and unfocused. Under the blanket her hand was still moving in that steady rhythm that made James's breathing uneven.

"Liam." My name came out breathy, distracted. "Baby, you look so exhausted."

"I'm fine."

"You're not fine. You're falling asleep in that chair." She rolled her hips forward and James made a low sound in his chest. She didn't look away from me. "Why don't you go up to bed? Get some sleep."

"I'm not tired."

"You are though." Her hand did something under the blanket that made James grip her waist harder. You've been yawning for the last twenty minutes."

"I haven't yawned once."

She bit her lip as James's fingers moved against her. "Didn't you see him yawning, James?"

James's eyes were closed, his jaw clenched. "Wasn't watching."

"See? Even James noticed." Her breath caught and she paused, steadied herself. "You should really go to get some sleep. We're just going to stay up talking anyway. You'll be bored."

"Doesn't look like talking to me."

She smiled, lazy and guilty. "We're just reminiscing about the summer. You weren't there, you wouldn't understand." Under the blanket she shifted and James's hips jerked up involuntarily. "It's boring for you, honestly."

"I'm not bored."

"But you look tired." She pressed herself closer against James, eliminating what little space remained between them. "The bed is so comfortable. That big king bed upstairs. Clean sheets. So much room." Her hand moved faster under the blanket and James cursed under his breath. "Wouldn't that be nice? To just stretch out and fall asleep?"

"I'm staying here."

"But why?" She finally turned away from me, bringing her mouth close to James's ear. Whatever she whispered made his eyes snap open, made his hands clutch at her. Then she looked back at me again. "Seriously, Liam. What's the point of staying up? We're not doing anything. We're just sitting here."

"Just sitting."

"James is affectionate." She ground down against him and he groaned. "But honestly we're just sitting and talking. Nothing that requires an audience." Her fingers traced patterns on his chest while her other hand worked steadily beneath the wool. "It might be better if you went upstairs."

"Jade..." James's voice was strained.

"What, baby?" She kissed his neck, his jaw. "Am I talking too much?" She stopped herself, smiled. "I'm just catching up with old friends."

I stood and her eyes tracked me, bright with something between triumph and arousal. "You're going up?"

"Going to get another beer."

"There's beer upstairs too. In the mini fridge in our room. You could just go up there. Take a whole six pack. Drink in bed. Pass out watching TV." Under the blanket her movements had become more urgent, more deliberate. "Doesn't that sound better than sitting down here?"

"Not really."

"Liam." She said my name like she was reasoning with a child. "Come on. You've had a long day. All that hiking this morning. And the party tonight. You must be dead on your feet." James's hand moved and she gasped, lost her train of thought for a moment. "You must be... God... you must be so ready to just close your eyes and..."

"I'm not leaving."

"Why not though?" Her voice had gone higher, breathier. "What's keeping you down here? It's late. It's past two in the morning. Normal people are asleep. You should be asleep. Upstairs in our room. Far away from..." She cut herself off, bit down on James's shoulder to muffle a sound.

"Far away from what?"

She pulled back to look at me, her hair wild, her lips swollen. "From boring conversations about the past. You'll just fall asleep if you stayed." Under the blanket she was trembling now, her whole body going taut. "Why don't you just... why don't you go upstairs and sleep instead of pretending to sleep down here?"

"I'm not pretending anything."

"Then what are you doing?" The question came out sharp, almost frustrated. "What's the point of sitting there staring at us?"

"Maybe I'm interested in the conversation."

"You're not." She was struggling to maintain focus now, her eyes trying to close, her body responding to whatever James was doing beneath the blanket. "You can't be. We're not even... we're barely even talking to you. We haven't included you in like twenty minutes."

"I noticed."

"So go to bed." It almost sounded like begging now. "Please, Liam. Just go upstairs. Let us finish our conversation. We'll be quiet. You won't even know we're down here."

Her voice had gone tight, strained. "You really should, oh..." She jerked suddenly, her free hand flying to James's wrist under the blanket. "You should really just go up and, stop that..." The last part was directed at James, whispered but urgent.

He said something too quiet for me to hear and she shook her head, then gasped, her body going rigid for a moment. "I'm trying to..." She squeezed her eyes shut. "I'm trying to have a conversation."

"Seems like you're having trouble focusing." I kept my voice even.

Her hips shifted forward and she had to bite her lip to keep quiet. "I'm perfectly, James, seriously..." She gripped his wrist tighter but didn't actually pull his hand away. "I'm perfectly capable of talking and, fuck..."

"And what?" I watched her struggle, watched her try to compose herself while whatever James was doing to her under the blanket continued relentlessly.

"Stting here having a nice..." She broke off with a barely suppressed moan, her head falling forward against James's shoulder. "Having a nice boring conversation that you don't need to, oh my god..." Her whole body shuddered and she laughed breathlessly into his neck. "That you don't need to witness."

Under the blanket her other hand moved sharply and James inhaled hard through his teeth. His hips jerked up and she made a satisfied sound and glared defiantly at him.

"Two can play," she whispered to him, loud enough for me to catch.

"That's not..." His words cut off as her hand did something that made his jaw clench. "Christ, Jade."

"What?" She was grinning now despite the obvious effect he was having on her. "I'm just sitting here. Just talking to my boyfriend about..." She gasped again, her thighs tensing. "About how he should go to bed."

"I can see how hard you're working on that conversation."

"I am working hard." Another involuntary movement, her back arching slightly. "It's hard to, stop, stop, stop..." She was laughing and moaning at the same time, squirming against James while simultaneously pressing closer. "It's hard to convince you when you're being so stubborn."

James's other hand slid up her side and she twisted away from it, which only seemed to give him better access to whatever he was doing under the blanket. She retaliated immediately, her hand moving in a way that made him grunt and grab her hip hard enough to jolt her.

"You're both..." She couldn't finish the sentence. Her breathing had gone ragged, her movements becoming less controlled. "You're both being so difficult right now."

"Am I being difficult?" James's voice was rough, amused.

"Yes." She grabbed his face with her hand and kissed him hard, then pulled back. "You're supposed to be helping me convince him to leave, not..." She was cut off with a strangled sound as his fingers apparently found something. "Not making this impossible."

"You started it." He was breathing hard too now, his hips moving in small thrusts against her hand.

"I didn't." But she was squirming in his lap, her body contradicting her words entirely. "I was just trying to, Liam, please..." She looked at me with desperate, unfocused eyes. "Please just go upstairs. Just go to our room and, oh fuck..."

Her hand moved decisively under the blanket and James made a choked sound, his head falling back. She looked pleased with herself for about two seconds before he doubled down on whatever he was doing to her and she had to bury her face in his shoulder to muffle her reaction.

Her voice was muffled against his skin. "This is why you should leave. This is so boring for you. Just two old friends catching up and..." She laughed breathlessly. "And apparently trying to kill each other."

"Doesn't look boring."

"It is." She was trembling now, her whole body taut as a wire. "Super boring. Incredibly boring. You're probably bored out of your mind watching us just sit here and, James, I swear to god if you don't..."

Whatever threat she was making dissolved into a whimper. Her thighs clenched around his hand and she went very still for a moment, clearly fighting to maintain some semblance of control. Then she squeezed whatever she was holding under the blanket and James cursed, his whole body going rigid.

"That's cheating," he managed.

"You cheated first." She was panting now, squirming and laughing and clearly losing the battle with her own arousal. "Liam, I'm serious, you need to, you need to go because we're going to..." She stopped herself, bit her lip hard. "Because you'll be miserable."

"I'm not miserable."

"You will be." Her voice had gone high and desperate. "You will be so miserable watching us sit here not doing anything at all just talking about boring old..." James's fingers moved and she actually squealed, then clapped her free hand over her mouth. "Just talking," she finished weakly.

Jade suddenly pushed herself up from James's lap, breaking contact. She was breathing hard, her hair wild, her shirt twisted halfway around her body. For a moment I thought she was about to say something to me, but instead she stumbled the few steps to the couch and collapsed onto it lengthwise, her head coming down on the armrest, her legs stretched out.

James followed without hesitation. He moved from the chair to the couch, settling his weight over her, one knee between her thighs, his hands bracing on either side of her head. The blanket came with him, still draped over both of them, covering them from the shoulders down.

Neither of them looked at me. Neither of them spoke.

The fire had burned down to almost nothing now, just a few faintly glowing embers that gave off barely any light. The room fell into deep shadow, the kind of darkness where shapes became suggestions, where I could see movement but not detail.

Under the blanket something was happening. I could see the shifting of fabric, the rhythm of bodies moving together. Jade's hands came up to grip James's shoulders, then slid down his back. Her head tilted to one side and he bent to her neck, her throat, the hollow of her collarbone.

She made a sound, soft and needy, and her legs shifted wider. The blanket moved with them, preserving the barrier between what I could see and what I could only imagine. James's hips settled lower and Jade's back arched off the couch.

They found a rhythm together, slow and grinding, nothing rushed but nothing innocent either. In the near darkness I watched the blanket rise and fall, watched their silhouettes merge and separate in tiny increments. Jade's breathing had changed entirely, coming in short gasps that she tried to muffle against James's shoulder.

His hand disappeared under the blanket between them and she went very still, then shuddered. Her fingers dug into his back hard enough that I could see the tension in her arms even in the darkness. He said something against her ear, too quiet to hear, and she nodded, then shook her head, then nodded again.

The movement between them intensified. Not faster, but deeper, more purposeful. Jade's hips were rising to meet him now, seeking something, chasing something. Her hands roamed across his back, his shoulders, sliding down to grip his ass through his jeans and pull him harder against her.

Then she released him and disappeared entirely under the blanket.

The shape of her body vanished beneath the dark fabric. Only James remained visible, kneeling on the couch now, his head falling back as the blanket moved in ways that made it very clear where Jade had gone, what she was doing.

His hand came down to rest on top of the blanket where her head must be, fingers spreading wide. His breathing had gone harsh and ragged. In the dying light of the embers I could see the tension in his jaw, the cords standing out in his neck.

The blanket moved steadily, rhythmically. James's other hand gripped the back of the couch hard enough that his knuckles went white. His hips shifted forward in small involuntary movements and he made a sound low in his throat that was pure surrender.

I sat in my chair in the darkness and watched the blanket move. Watched James's head fall forward, his whole body curling over whatever Jade was doing beneath the wool. Watched him struggle to stay quiet and fail, soft curses falling from his lips.

Under the blanket Jade was completely hidden, completely committed to whatever she had decided to do. The barrier of fabric meant I could see nothing, but my imagination filled in every detail.

Jade emerged from under the blanket gasping for air, her hair completely wild, her shirt gone. Her bra was still on but twisted, one strap falling down her shoulder. She didn't bother to fix it. didn't look to see if I was watching. She straddled James immediately, settling her weight onto his lap with her knees on either side of his hips.

Her jeans were still on but unbuttoned, hanging low on her hips. James's hands went to her waist, her ribs, sliding up to cup her breasts through the thin lace. She arched into his touch and rolled her hips forward, grinding down against the hard length of him still trapped in his jeans.

"Fuck." The word fell from her lips like a prayer. She did it again, harder this time, and James groaned.

His hands moved to her ass, gripping her through the denim, guiding her movements. She set a rhythm, slow and deliberate, sliding herself along the rigid line of him with the denim between them providing the only barrier. Both their jeans were open and unzipped. Her head fell back and she rode him like that, chasing friction, chasing heat, completely lost in the sensation.

In the near darkness I could see the curve of her spine, the way her body moved like water, fluid and relentless. She was making sounds now, soft whimpers and gasps that she was not even trying to suppress. Her hands braced on James's shoulders and she ground down harder, faster, her hips rolling in tight circles.

"Jesus, Jade." James's voice was wrecked. His hands slid under her open jeans, cupping bare skin, pulling her down harder against him.

"I know." She was panting, her movements becoming more erratic, more desperate. "I can't, I can't stop."

He pulled her down into a kiss, messy and open-mouthed, while her hips kept moving in that relentless rhythm.

She broke away to breathe, her forehead pressed against his. "This is so fucked up."

"I know."

"We shouldn't..." But even as she said it she was grinding harder, seeking more pressure, more contact. "We can't..."

His hands went still on her hips, giving her the choice.

She made a frustrated sound and grabbed his wrists, put his hands back where they had been. "Don't stop."

He groaned and pulled her down against him, his hips thrusting up to meet her. The friction made her cry out, loud enough that she immediately bit her lip, trying to stay quiet. But her body wouldn't stop moving, couldn't stop chasing what it wanted.

Her bra came off, or maybe James unhooked it. It fell away and his mouth found her breast, his tongue circling her nipple while she rode him harder. She tangled her fingers in his hair and held him there, her head thrown back in abandon.

She was completely unselfconscious now, her body moving with pure instinct. The slow grind had become something more urgent, more primal. She was rubbing herself against him with single-minded intensity, the seam of her jeans and the hard ridge of his cock creating pressure exactly where she needed it.

James's hands roamed everywhere, mapping the curves of her body, squeezing and gripping and pulling her closer. His mouth moved from her breast to her neck, her jaw, back to her mouth in a kiss that was more teeth than lips.

She was quiet for a heartbeat, still moving, still chasing. Then she laughed breathlessly.

Her movements became wild, uncoordinated. She was grinding and writhing against him with complete abandon, her hands clutching at his shoulders, his hair, anything she could grip. The sounds falling from her lips were pure desperation, need stripped of any pretense or control.

James watched her face, his hands never stopping their guidance, his hips thrusting up to give her more friction.

Her whole body went taut and she froze for a moment, balanced on the edge. Then she shattered, crying out as her body convulsed against him, her

hips jerking through wave after wave of pleasure.

He held her, his hands gentle now, soothing. When she finally went limp against his chest she was gasping for breath, her skin slick with sweat in the dying firelight.

For a long moment there was only the sound of breathing. Then Jade stirred, lifting her head to look at James with heavy-lidded eyes.

Her hand moved between them without hesitation, finding the rigid length of him still trapped in his jeans. Her fingers worked at his zipper.

Jade slid off his lap and onto her knees on the floor between his legs. She didn't hesitate, didn't look back at me sitting in the darkness. Her hands went to his belt, fingers working the buckle with efficiency. The metallic click seemed loud in the quiet room.

James lifted his hips to help her as she pulled his jeans down, not all the way off, just far enough that when she freed him from his boxers he was exposed to the cool air, hard and ready in her grip.

She wrapped her fingers around him and he made a low sound in his chest. She stroked him slowly, base to tip, feeling the shape of him again or maybe remembering. Her thumb swept across the head and his hips jerked involuntarily.

Then she leaned forward and took him in her mouth.

His head fell back against the couch, his hand immediately going into her hair, not pulling, not guiding, just tangling his fingers in the strands like he needed something to hold onto. His other hand gripped the cushion beside him.

Jade worked him with her mouth, taking him deeper with each movement. I could see the line of her back in the darkness, the way her body curved as she leaned into him. I could see the gentle bobbing motion of her head, could hear the soft wet sounds that made my stomach clench.

She pulled back to the tip, her tongue doing something that made James curse under his breath. Then she took him deep again, deeper than before, until I heard her gag. She didn't pull away. Instead she held there for a moment before sliding back up.

Her hand worked what her mouth couldn't reach, stroking in rhythm with the movement of her head. James's breathing had gone ragged, his fingers tightening in her hair. She made a humming sound around him and his whole body shuddered.

She found a steady pace, not rushed, taking her time with him. Sometimes she would pull off entirely to catch her breath, her hand still stroking while she pressed kisses along his length, his inner thigh, anywhere she could reach. Then her mouth would return, taking him in again with purpose.

James was struggling to stay still, his hips wanting to thrust but holding back. She seemed to sense it because she used her free hand to grip his hip, holding him in place while she controlled the pace. He groaned at the restraint, at being forced to take what she was giving him rather than taking what he wanted.

She varied her rhythm, sometimes slow and teasing, sometimes faster and more intense. Her head would bob rapidly for several strokes and then she would slow down again, drawing it out, making it last. Every time James seemed to get close she would back off, would pull away to just licking and kissing him until his breathing steadied.

Her hand twisted as she stroked him, adding friction and pressure. Her mouth followed, taking him deep and then pulling back with suction that made him gasp. She was working him methodically, knowing what made him tense, what made him moan, what made his fingers tighten painfully in her hair.

Saliva dripped down her chin but she didn't stop to wipe it away. She kept going, kept taking him deeper, kept building that steady rhythm that was clearly driving him toward the edge. Her other hand moved to cup him below, adding another layer of sensation that made his breath catch.

James's head lifted and he looked down at her, watching her mouth work on him in the dim light. The sight seemed to undo something in him because his control started slipping. His hips began moving in small thrusts to meet her mouth and she let him, adjusted her pace to match his movements.

She could sense he was getting close. Her movements became more focused, more deliberate. She took him as deep as she could manage and held him there, swallowing around him, before pulling back to focus on the head. Her hand stroked faster now, matching the increased speed of her mouth.

James's breathing had become harsh pants. His hand in her hair tightened and she made an encouraging sound around him, giving

permission. His hips started thrusting more urgently and she opened her throat to take it, to let him use her mouth the way he needed.

His whole body went taut. His fingers twisted in her hair almost painfully and he tried to pull her away, tried to warn her, but she held firm. She kept her mouth on him, kept stroking him, kept working him through it.

He came with a strangled groan, his hips jerking up as he spilled into her mouth. She took it all, swallowing, not pulling away until he was finished, until his body had gone slack against the couch and his hand had loosened in her hair.

Only then did she pull off, wiping her mouth with the back of her hand. She sat back on her heels between his legs, breathing hard, her bare chest rising and falling in the darkness. James's hand came down to cup her face, his thumb brushing across her swollen lips.

She turned her head and kissed his palm. Then she climbed back up onto the couch, curling against his side like nothing had happened, like I was not sitting ten feet away watching the whole thing.

James pulled the blanket over both of them, tucking it around Jade's bare shoulders. His arm wrapped around her and she nestled into the crook of his body, her head on his chest, one leg hooked over his thigh. They lay there breathing together, their bodies still trembling slightly with aftershocks.

After a moment James shifted, rolling Jade onto her back on the couch. She went willingly, her arms reaching up to pull him down with her. The blanket stayed draped over them both as he settled between her legs, propped on one elbow above her.

He kissed her slowly, thoroughly, taking his time now. His free hand slid down her body, tracing the curve of her breast, her ribs, her stomach. When he reached the waistband of her jeans she lifted her hips without being asked.

He worked the denim down her legs, taking her underwear with it. The clothes disappeared somewhere under or beside the couch. Then his hand returned, sliding up her inner thigh with clear intent.

Jade's whole body reacted. She gasped and her legs fell open wide, her back arching off the couch. When his fingers found her she cried out, her hips bucking up to meet his hand.

Her hands clutched at his shoulders, nails digging into his skin. She was making sounds continuously now, whimpers and moans that spilled from

her throat without any attempt at control. Her body moved with him, seeking more contact, more pressure.

James kissed down her neck while his hand worked between her legs. Jade was writhing beneath him, grinding herself against his fingers, her head thrown back, mouth open in pleasure.

He adjusted his position, sliding down her body. The blanket moved with him and when his mouth replaced his fingers Jade's whole body convulsed. Her hands flew to his head, gripping his hair as her thighs fell open wider.

The sounds she made filled the room, cries of pleasure that came from deep in her chest. She was grinding against his face, her hips moving in desperate circles, chasing what she needed.

Her body was in constant motion, writhing and bucking beneath him. One hand stayed tangled in his hair while the other gripped the couch cushions. Her head thrashed from side to side, her hair wild across her face.

I could see her silhouette in the darkness, the arch of her spine, the way her legs had draped over his shoulders. I could hear every gasp and moan. She was completely uninhibited, taking her pleasure without shame.

James gripped her hips and she ground harder against him, using his mouth exactly how she wanted. Her movements were frantic, urgent, building toward something inevitable.

Her whole body went rigid. Then she shattered with a cry that echoed through the cottage, her back bowing off the couch, every muscle taut with release.

She rode the waves of it, hips still moving against his mouth, drawing it out as long as possible. When the intensity finally crested she was gasping and laughing breathlessly with the sheer pleasure of it.

But before she had even fully recovered, before her breathing had steadied, she was pulling at James, dragging him back up over her body. Her hands went immediately to his hips with urgent movements.

She wrapped her legs around his waist, pulling him against her. They were both completely naked now under the blanket, skin against skin. She reached between them and positioned him, her hand guiding him where she wanted him.

Their eyes met in the darkness. Some unspoken question passed between them. Then Jade lifted her hips and pulled him down simultaneously, and she grunted as he slid into her in one smooth motion.

They both went still for a heartbeat, foreheads pressed together, adjusting to the sensation. Then Jade's hips rolled up and James groaned, his control snapping. He began to move, pulling back and thrusting forward, finding a rhythm that made Jade cry out with each stroke.

Her legs locked around him, heels digging into his lower back. Her hands roamed everywhere, across his shoulders, down his spine, gripping his ass to pull him deeper. The blanket slipped down to their waists now, exposing her breasts, her flushed skin.

James braced himself on one elbow and used his hand to grip her hip, changing the angle. Jade's head fell back and she moaned, her whole body arching into him. He thrust harder and she matched him, meeting each movement with her own.

The couch creaked with their rhythm. The blanket slipped further. Neither of them cared. They were lost in each other, in the heat building between them, in the slick slide of bodies that fit together like they had never been apart.

Jade's nails scratched down James's back. He buried his face in her neck, his breath hot against her skin. Their movements became more urgent, more desperate. The careful control from earlier had evaporated entirely.

Then Jade pushed at his chest, twisting beneath him. He pulled out and she flipped onto her stomach, rising up on her hands and knees. She looked back at him over her shoulder, hair wild, eyes dark with desperate want.

James moved behind her, his hands gripping her hips. He entered her again from this angle and she cried out, dropping down to her elbows. He set a punishing pace, pulling her back onto him with each thrust.

Jade was vocal now, making unrestrained sounds of pleasure with every stroke. Her hands clutched at the couch cushions while her body rocked with the force of his movements. The new angle was hitting something that made her gasp and moan continuously.

James's hand slid up her spine, tangled in her hair, pulling her head back. She arched beautifully, her back curving as he drove into her. His other hand stayed on her hip, fingers digging into flesh, holding her exactly where he wanted her.

They stayed like that for several minutes, the sound of skin meeting skin filling the room along with Jade's increasingly desperate cries. Then she reached back, her hand finding his thigh, slowing him.

She pulled away and turned, pushing him down onto the couch on his back. The blanket fell away completely now, forgotten. She straddled him, sinking down onto him in one smooth motion that made them both groan.

She rode him hard, her hands braced on his chest for leverage, her hips rolling and grinding. James's hands came up to cup her breasts, thumbs circling her nipples, and she threw her head back with a guttural moan.

She was stunning in the dim light, all curves and movement, completely uninhibited. Her body moved like water, fluid and relentless. She would grind down in tight circles, then lift up and slam back down, changing rhythm unpredictably, keeping him on edge.

James sat up suddenly, wrapping his arms around her waist, changing the angle again. Now they were chest to chest, faces inches apart, breathing each other's air. Jade's arms went around his neck and she continued to move on him, slower now but deeper, taking him to the hilt with each roll of her hips.

They kissed messily while she rode him, tongues tangling, teeth catching lips. His hands roamed her back, her ass, everywhere he could reach. She was whimpering into his mouth, the sounds muffled but constant.

She pushed him back down and leaned forward, her hands on either side of his head. Her breasts hung above his face and he sucked a nipple into his mouth while she continued to move on him. She gasped and ground down harder, chasing the friction.

Then James gripped her hips and flipped them again, this time pulling her to the edge of the couch. Her legs went over his shoulders and he stood, using the new angle to thrust into her deeper. Jade's back arched off the couch and she grabbed for anything to hold onto, finally gripping the armrest above her head.

This position let him go deeper than before and Jade was making sounds I had never heard from her, high keening cries of pleasure mixed with gasps and moans. Her free hand came down to where they were joined, touching herself while he moved inside her.

James watched her touch herself and it seemed to drive him wild. His thrusts became harder, faster. The couch was definitely going to have damage after this, the frame creaking ominously with each impact.

Jade's hand moved faster on herself and her other hand gripped the armrest. She was close, I could see it in the tension of her body, but James

suddenly pulled out and flipped her over again.

This time he pulled her hips up so she was kneeling on the couch facing the back of it, hands braced on the cushions. He entered her from behind again but this time he leaned over her, one arm wrapping around to touch her where she had been touching herself.

Jade practically screamed. The combination of sensations had her shaking, her arms barely holding her up. James's other hand gripped her shoulder, using it for leverage as he pounded into her while his fingers worked her clit.

She was babbling now, incoherent sounds and half-words. Her head hung down between her arms, hair making a curtain over her face. Every muscle in her body was pulled taut, straining toward release.

James sat back on the couch and pulled her into his lap facing away from him, her back to his chest. She sank down onto him and he guided her legs over his, spreading her wide.

His hands came around to touch her breasts, her stomach, between her legs while she rode him backward. She leaned her head back on his shoulder, completely exposed, completely open. One of her hands covered his between her legs, guiding his fingers where she needed them.

The position let me see everything in the shadows, see how they moved together, see where they were joined, see Jade's face go slack with pleasure as she bounced in his lap.

She turned her head and they kissed sloppily over her shoulder while maintaining their rhythm. His hips thrust up to meet her downward movements. The wet sounds of sex mixed with their breathing and Jade's constant moans.

Jade pulled off and pushed James back down on the couch. She took him in her mouth again, tasting them both, making him groan and grip her hair. Then she climbed back on top, facing him this time, sinking down onto him once more.

She set a grinding rhythm, slow and careful, her hands on his chest. James's hands gripped her hips but let her control the pace. She was taking her time now, rolling her hips in figure eights, finding angles that made her gasp.

They had been going for so long, both of them were covered in sweat despite the cool air. Jade's hair stuck to her neck and shoulders. James's chest heaved with exertion. But neither showed any sign of stopping.

Jade leaned down to kiss him deeply while continuing to move. Their bodies slid together, slick with sweat. The room smelled of sex, musky and thick. Every surface of the couch would need cleaning.

I had lost track of time entirely. I had lost track of how many positions they had tried, how many times they had brought each other to the edge only to back off. They seemed determined to explore every possibility, to make up for all the lost time in a single night.

Jade was still moving on top of James, still grinding down onto him with that slow rhythm. Then she stopped. She went completely still, straddling him, breathing hard. Her hands rested on his chest and she sat there for a long moment, feeling him inside her.

That's when she looked over at me for the first time in hours. Her eyes found me in the shadows where I had been sitting frozen in my chair.

"I'm sorry." Her voice was hoarse, wrecked from all the sounds she had been making. "I'm so sorry, Liam."

She climbed off James slowly, unsteadily. She bent to gather the blanket and wrapped it around herself, covering her naked body. James sat up on the couch, watching her, his chest still heaving.

Jade held out her hand. He took it without hesitation and stood. They didn't look at me again as they crossed the room together, hand in hand, both of them naked except for the blanket Jade had clutched around her shoulders.

They climbed the stairs. I heard their footsteps on the creaking boards, heard them reach the second floor landing. I heard a door open and close, James's bedroom, the master suite at the end of the hall.

I sat in the darkness listening. For a while there was nothing. Then I heard laughter, Jade's bright peal of delight followed by James's lower rumble, the sounds of happiness, of ease, of two people comfortable with each other.

Then silence again long enough that I thought maybe they had gone to sleep.

But then I heard it, the creak of bedsprings, rhythmic and unmistakable. Jade's voice rose in that familiar pitch, muffled by the walls and the closed door but still audible, still clear enough that I knew exactly what was happening.

The sounds went on. And on. The bed frame hit the wall in a steady tempo. Jade cried out. James's made occasional deeper groans. Sometimes

the rhythm would speed up, become frantic. Then it would slow down. They were taking their time, starting over, going again.

I finally rose from my chair. My legs were stiff from sitting so long. I walked to the stairs and climbed them slowly. The sounds from James's room got louder as I reached the second floor. Jade wasn't trying to be quiet anymore. Maybe she had forgotten I existed again. Or maybe she just didn't care.

I walked past James's door. Through it I could hear everything, the slap of skin on skin, Jade begging, James's response too low to make out. More laughter, more moans, the unmistakable sounds of bodies slapping again and again.

I reached the room Jade and I were supposed to share. I opened the door and stood there looking at the pristine bed with its clean lavender-scented sheets.

Down the hall Jade cried out, loud and long. The bed frame slammed against the wall harder. I heard James say something and Jade's breathless response, more laughter, all the sounds of pleasure without any shame or restraint.

I closed the door but it didn't block out the noise. The old cottage walls were too thin. I could hear everything, every moan, every gasp, every time the bed hit the wall. I could picture exactly what they were doing even though I couldn't see them anymore.

I lay down on the bed and stared at the ceiling. I listened to my girlfriend fuck another man in the room down the hall, listened to her sound happier, more free, more satisfied than I had ever heard her.

The sounds went on for a long time. Eventually they would quiet down and I would think they were finally done. Then it would start up again, a new round, a new position, Jade's voice rising in ecstasy over and over.

I didn't sleep. I just lay there in the darkness, listening, while the night stretched on endlessly around me.

The confusion of what I felt was almost worse than any single emotion would have been. Anger, yes. That hot tight feeling in my chest that made me want to put my fist through the wall. But also something else. Something I didn't want to examine too closely.

The truth was, I had been hard the whole night. My jeans were uncomfortable, restrictive. I had watched my girlfriend fuck another man and my body had responded in ways my mind couldn't reconcile. The

shame of that mixed with the anger, creating something toxic and complicated that I didn't know how to process.

Obviously it was over between us. Whatever Jade and I had been was finished the moment she straddled James on that couch. Maybe it had been finished long before that.

Down the hall Jade cried out again. The headboard slammed against the wall. I heard her laugh breathlessly, heard James say something that made her laugh harder. They sounded happy and carefree.

I closed my eyes but that made it worse because then all I could do was picture what they were doing. I opened my eyes and went back to staring at the ceiling, counting the cracks in the plaster, trying to focus on anything except the sounds from down the hall.

Eventually the house fell quiet. I checked my phone. It was four thirty in the morning. I lay there in the silence, exhausted but unable to sleep. Every time I started to drift off I would hear something, a creak of bedsprings, a soft murmur of voices. It would jolt me awake again. But I was imagining it now. They were both happily asleep.

When I finally did fall asleep it was fitful, broken. I dreamed in fragments that I couldn't remember when I woke up. It was all just impressions of bodies moving in darkness, of being invisible, of watching something I couldn't stop.

I woke for good at six thirty. Gray dawn light was filtering through the curtains. The cottage was silent. I lay there for a few more minutes, then got up and went to the bathroom down the hall. I avoided looking at James's closed door as I passed it.

In the bathroom I splashed cold water on my face and looked at myself in the mirror. I looked exactly like someone who had spent the night listening to his girlfriend fuck someone else. Dark circles were under my eyes. Hair stuck up at odd angles. I had a hollow exhausted look that went deeper than lack of sleep.

I went back to the room and got a new shirt, pulled on clean socks. I packed my bag quietly and efficiently. Everything I had brought for the weekend went back into my duffel. It only took five minutes.

I carried the bag downstairs and set it by the front door. Then I went to the kitchen and started making coffee. The mechanical process of grinding beans, measuring water, waiting for it to brew gave me something to focus on. The smell of coffee filled the kitchen, rich and normal.

I was pouring my first cup when I heard it from upstairs. The unmistakable creak of bedsprings starting up again. Then Jade's voice, softer than last night but still audible in the quiet morning house, a moan, a gasp. The familiar rhythm building.

I stood in the kitchen holding my coffee cup and listened to them fuck all over again. I listened to Jade's breathless laughter between moans. I heard James's low rumble of response. I heard the bed settling into a steady rhythm.

They sounded relaxed and comfortable, like they had all the time in the world, like this was how they wanted to start their Sunday morning, together, in his bed, in his cottage, continuing what they had started last night.

I drank my coffee standing at the counter. The sounds from upstairs continued. They weren't frantic like last night, they were slower, lazier. It was morning sex, the kind of comfortable intimacy that came from knowing someone's body well. Or from spending all night relearning it.

There was more soft laughter from Jade and then more bed creaking. She said something I couldn't make out and James responded and she laughed again.

I finished my coffee and rinsed the cup in the sink. The sounds from upstairs were building now, Jade's voice getting higher, more urgent. I walked to the front door and picked up my bag.

I should leave a note at least, I thought. I should tell Jade I was leaving. But what would I say? What words existed for this situation?

Instead I just opened the front door and stepped out into the cold morning air. Behind me I heard Jade cry out one more time, heard the bedsprings give a final protesting creak. Then the house fell silent again except for the soft murmur of voices I couldn't hear.

I closed the door quietly behind me and walked to my car. I had the hatch open and was loading my duffel when I heard the front door open behind me. I didn't turn around, didn't want to see who was coming out. But I heard the footsteps on the gravel.

"Liam, wait."

I closed the hatch and turned. Jade stood there barefoot on the cold gravel, wearing only James's stretched out tank. It hung to mid-thigh on her, the arm holes so large they showed the curve of her breasts. Her hair was wild, She clearly just rolled out of bed. Her lips were puffy from action.

She wrapped her arms around herself against the morning chill. "Where are you going?"

"Home."

"But we were supposed to stay through today. Have brunch. Everyone's still asleep." She took a step closer. "Come back inside. It's freezing out here."

"I'm leaving, Jade."

"Why?" She looked genuinely confused, like she couldn't understand why I would want to leave. "Is this about last night?"

I just stared at her.

"Liam, come on. We were just catching up. James and I have history. It was just... we got carried away. It didn't mean anything." The words came out practiced, like she had been rehearsing them upstairs.

"It didn't mean anything?"

"No. I mean, yes, it was fun, but it's not like..." She trailed off, seeming to realize how that sounded. "You're my boyfriend. Last night was just... it was just old times. Getting caught up."

She closed the distance between us and reached for my hand. I let her take it, too numb to pull away.

"Please don't leave. Not like this. We can talk about it." Her thumb rubbed circles on the back of my hand. "It doesn't have to be weird."

"Doesn't have to be weird?"

"You're just repeating what I'm saying." She laughed a bit and stepped even closer, pressing her body against mine. Through the thin top I could feel the heat of her skin, could smell sex on her, musky and unmistakable. "Talk to me. Tell me what you're thinking."

"I'm thinking you fucked James last night. Multiple times. In front of me. And then went to his bed and kept fucking him."

"Okay, yes, that happened." She said it like she was admitting to staying up too late or drinking too much. "But it doesn't change us. You and me. We're still together."

She rose up on her toes and kissed me. Her mouth was hot against mine. Her lips felt different, rubbed raw. Oversensitive.

She kissed me deeply, her tongue sliding into my mouth. I tasted it immediately, the unmistakable taste of another man, salty and bitter and hot. She must have sucked James off this morning, probably right before

she came down to me. The taste of his cum was still in her mouth and she was kissing me with it, sharing it like it was nothing.

I pulled back. She chased my mouth, trying to kiss me again.

"Jade, stop."

"What?" She was breathing hard, her pupils dilated. "I'm just trying to show you that we're okay. That nothing's changed between us."

"Everything's changed."

"It hasn't though." Her hand slid down to my belt, fingers working at the buckle. "Let me prove it to you. Let me show you I'm still yours."

I caught her wrist. "Don't."

"Why?" Her other hand was already at my zipper. "I want you. We can go back inside, go to our room. I'll make you feel so good, baby. Better than..."

"Better than James made you feel?"

She stopped. Pulled her hands back. "That's not what I was going to say."

"But it's what you were thinking."

"Liam, please." She was pleading now, her eyes wide. "Don't do this. Don't ruin everything over one night. It was just sex. Just physical. It didn't mean anything compared to what we have."

"What do we have, Jade?"

She opened her mouth and closed it and looked away. "We have... we're good together. We have fun. We..."

"We had something. Past tense." I walked around to the driver's side door. "It's over."

"No." She followed me, grabbing my arm. "No, you don't get to just leave. We need to talk about this. We need to figure this out together."

"There's nothing to figure out." I opened the door. "You made your choice last night."

"I didn't choose anything. I just..." She was crying now, tears emerging down her face. "Please, Liam. Please don't go. Last night was just a mistake that we can work through."

I looked at her standing there in James's shirt, sobbing, begging me to stay. Part of me wanted to believe her, wanted to think that maybe she was right, that it was just one night, just a mistake that could be forgiven.

But I could still taste James in her mouth. I could still hear the sounds she made last night, the way she had screamed his name. I could still see the

way she had looked at him like he was the only person in the world.

"Go back inside, Jade. You're freezing."

"I don't care." But she was shivering, her bare feet turning red on the cold gravel.

"Go back to James. That's where you want to be anyway."

"Please, Liam. Please just stay. Let me explain. Not out here in the cold. Come inside. We can talk." She was sobbing now, her whole body shaking.

"It was a one-time thing. Old feelings from years ago. It just bubbled up and we got carried away but it's done now. It's out of our systems."

"Jade..."

"Please." She grabbed my arm through the open car door. "I love you. I chose you three years ago and I'm choosing you now. Last night was just... it was closure. It was me and James finally finishing something that never got finished. But it's done now. We're done. I swear."

"One day." I heard myself saying it before I had fully decided. "We stay today like we planned. We talk. Then we leave together tonight."

"Yes." She nodded frantically. "Yes, okay. Thank you. Thank you, Liam." She pulled me out of the car and wrapped her arms around me, pressing her whole body against mine. "I promise. I promise it meant nothing. It was just old times. Just getting it out of our systems."

I held her while she cried against my chest. She felt familiar in my arms. Maybe she was right. Maybe it had just been one night of old feelings resurfacing. Maybe we could get past it.

"I need to get dressed." She pulled back and wiped her eyes. "Come inside. I'll make us breakfast. We can have a normal day. Like none of this happened."

We went inside together. The living room still smelled like sex and smoke from the dead fire. Jade grabbed my hand and led me upstairs, past James's closed door to our room. She pulled me inside and closed the door behind us.

"Let me shower first." She kissed my cheek. "Then we can start fresh."

While she was in the bathroom I sat on the bed and tried to organize my thoughts. I tried to convince myself that staying was the right choice, that one night didn't have to define everything, that people made mistakes and relationships survived them.

The day passed in a strange approximation of normalcy. Other people woke up hungover and stumbled to the kitchen for coffee. Jade made

pancakes. Everyone sat around the big dining table eating and laughing about the party the night before. James was there, too, fully dressed now, charming as always. He and Jade barely looked at each other, barely spoke.

Maybe she was right. Maybe it really was over.

We went for a walk in the afternoon, just the two of us. Jade held my hand and talked about work, about her sister's upcoming wedding, about normal things. She was trying so hard. I could see the effort in every smile, every squeeze of my hand.

That night most people left, Sunday evening departures to get home for work the next day. By dinner it was just a handful of us left including James. We ordered pizza and watched a movie in the living room. Jade sat next to me on the couch, her head on my shoulder, her hand in mine.

When the movie ended James said goodnight and headed upstairs. A few others drifted off to their rooms. Soon it was just Jade and me.

"Bed?" She stood and held out her hand.

We went upstairs to our room. She undressed slowly, letting me watch. When she turned I saw marks on her hips, finger-shaped bruises from where James had gripped her, a faint red mark on her neck that her hair had been hiding all day.

The sight of them should have made me angry, should have made me sick. Instead I felt heat flood through me, felt myself getting hard watching her stand there marked by another man.

She came to me and undressed me with gentle hands. When she touched me she felt my reaction immediately, felt how hard I was. She looked up at me with surprise and something else, something perhaps knowing.

She didn't say anything, just kissed me and pushed me back onto the bed.

When she climbed on top of me I couldn't stop looking at those marks on her hips. I could not stop thinking about James's hands there, gripping her while he fucked her. The thought made me harder, made me throb inside her.

Jade noticed. She started moving on me, riding me with slow rolls of her hips. She leaned down and whispered in my ear. "You're so hard for me, why?"

I groaned and gripped her hips exactly where James's fingerprints were. She gasped and moved faster.

I was more aroused than I had ever been. Every time I closed my eyes I saw her on that couch with James, saw her head thrown back in ecstasy, heard the sounds she had made. It drove me wild in ways I didn't want to examine.

Jade could feel it, she could feel the intensity in how I touched her, how I moved with her. She matched it, riding me harder, her nails digging into my chest.

When I flipped her onto her back she wrapped her legs around me and pulled me deeper. I thrust into her with more force, chasing it. She responded with enthusiasm, meeting every movement, encouraging me with gasps and moans.

I was thinking about her with James. I could not stop thinking about it, about how she had looked taking him in her mouth, how she had screamed when he made her come, how she had disappeared under that blanket. Every image made me thrust into her harder, made me grip her tighter.

Jade seemed to sense where my mind had gone even though I said nothing. Her eyes stayed locked on mine, dark and knowing. She said my name, told me she loved me. But there was something else in her expression, an awareness of what was driving me crazy even if neither of us acknowledged it.

When we finished we were both breathing hard, covered in sweat despite the cool room. I rolled off her and she curled against my side, her head on my chest.

"See?" She traced patterns on my skin. "We're okay. We're going to be fine."

"Yeah." I stroked her hair. "We are I guess."

But I couldn't deny the unusual intensity of what had just happened. I could feel how my body had responded to the knowledge of what she had done, how the jealousy and the arousal had tangled together into something confusing and powerful.

She was quiet for a while. Then she stirred. "I should just say goodnight to James. Before he goes to sleep. Since we're leaving early tomorrow. It would be rude not to."

"Jade..."

"Just goodnight. Two minutes." She was already sliding out of bed, pulling on her sleep shirt and shorts. "I'll be right back."

She slipped out the door before I could stop her. I heard her footsteps going down the hall, heard the soft knock on James's door, heard it open and close.

I lay there in the dark and waited. My body still hummed from what we had just done. I was still confused by my own reactions.

Two minutes passed. Then five. Then ten.

I checked my phone. It was eleven thirty. I tried to sleep. I told myself she was just talking to him, saying a proper goodbye to an old friend, getting real closure this time.

Midnight came and went. I got up and opened our door and listened. The house was completely silent. James's door was closed. No light showed under it.

I went back to bed and stared at the ceiling. I felt myself getting hard again just thinking about where she was, what she might be doing.

At one in the morning I heard it start, the creak of bedsprings down the hall, soft at first, then building. Then Jade's voice, muffled but unmistakable. Those same sounds from last night.

I lay there listening and my body responded in ways my mind rejected. I was hard, aching, aroused by the sounds of my girlfriend fucking another man down the hall all over again. And right after fucking me.

The sounds continued, they stopped and started again. Jade cried out and mixed with James's lower groans. There came the rhythmic slam of the headboard.

I listened to all of it all over. I could not make myself not listen. My hand moved down my body almost without conscious thought.

I finally heard James's door open and I heard Jade's footsteps in the hall. Our door opened and she slipped inside, closing it quietly behind her.

I kept my eyes closed and felt the bed dip as she climbed in beside me.

She smelled like sex like sweat and James and hours of fucking. The scent made me throb with unwanted arousal even as my chest tightened with something darker.

She curled against my back like nothing happened, like she had just been gone for two minutes instead of 30. Her body was hot, loose, and thoroughly used.

"Liam?" She whispered. "Are you awake?"

I didn't answer, didn't move, didn't trust what I might say or do.

She was quiet for a moment. Then she pressed a kiss between my shoulder blades. Her hand slid around to rest on my stomach, then lower. She felt how hard I was and went still.

"Oh," she breathed. It was so quiet I almost didn't hear it.

Her hand wrapped around me through my boxers. She squeezed gently. I couldn't stop the sharp intake of breath, couldn't pretend to be asleep anymore.

"Liam." She said my name differently now, understanding something. "You're..."

"Don't." My voice came out rough.

But she didn't let go. Her hand moved slowly, stroking me. "You were listening."

It was not a question.

I didn't answer but my body answered for me, responding to her touch with shameful eagerness.

"You were listening to us." She pressed closer against my back, her lips at my ear. "And now you're so hard."

"Jade, stop."

"But do you want me to stop?" Her hand moved faster.

I rolled over to face her. Her eyes were wide in the darkness, pupils dilated. She looked wrecked and satisfied and somehow hungry for more.

We didn't talk about it. We just moved together, my hands finding her body still slick and sensitive from James. When I entered her she was so ready, so open. The thought of why made me thrust harder, made me grip her hair, made me fuck her with an intensity that bordered on violence.

She took it all, even encouraged it. She met every thrust with her hips, every grip with her nails in my back. She cried out loud enough I was sure James could hear her. When she came it was with my name on her lips but I couldn't stop thinking about whose name had been on her lips an hour ago.

Afterwards we lay tangled together in the ruined sheets. Neither of us spoke.

She fell asleep quickly, exhausted from the night. I lay there staring at the ceiling, trying to understand what was happening to me and to us.

I had to understand why the worst night of my life had also been the most arousing.